

ANI

THE LONG AND WINDING ROAD

Nov. 3, 2023: The **Siddaramaiah** government forms a technical committee to inquire into allegations of various illegalities in MUDA site allocations

July 2024: Controversy arises over 14 sites the CM's wife Parvathi B.M. was allotted by MUDA in 2021 during the BJP regime. The sites, estimated at Rs 55.80 crore, were allotted as compensation for land encroached by MUDA

July 14: Siddaramaiah sets up a judicial commission to probe all MUDA allegations

Oct. 7: CM announces move to take up caste census report for discussion in upcoming cabinet meeting

Sept. 30: ED takes up an inquiry into MUDA case; Parvathi returns her 14 sites to MUDA

Sept. 29: CM promises to implement caste census at an event in Mysuru

Sept. 28: Lokayukta police file FIR against Siddaramaiah, his wife Parvathi and brother-in-law B.M. Mallikarjunaswamy

Sept. 26: Karnataka withdraws general consent given to the Central Bureau of Investigation

than what had been estimated all along. Though the 'leak' was dismissed as fake, the survey report was submitted only in 2018, by which time Siddaramaiah had demitted office. The succeeding governments shelved the report on the technical grounds that the member secretary of the Karnataka State Commission for Backward Classes hadn't signed it. The report was subsequently referred to the commission's new chairman, K. Jayaprakash Hegde, who submitted it to the government in February. In all likelihood, the CM will appoint a cabinet sub-committee to study the report and come up with recommendations for its implementation, which has been a Congress election manifesto promise. "The caste census report was handed to Siddaramaiah before the Lok Sabha election. Even after receiving the report, why has there been no discussion about it until now?" asked H.D. Kumaraswamy, a former CM and now Union minister of heavy industries and steel. "They have brought up the caste census issue to cover up the MUDA scam."

The MUDA case has been in the forefront since the Karnataka High Court in September upheld an order by Governor Thaawar Chand Gehlot for a probe into the complaints alleging corruption. Siddaramaiah has declared that he is ready to face any inquiry and claims that no illegality had taken place because his wife had only been compensated for the land lost during the formation of a housing layout. However, on September 30, barely two days after the Lokayukta police filed an FIR against the CM in Mysuru, the ED launched an inquiry under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), triggering a sharp response from the Congress that has been accusing the BJP of trying to dislodge the Siddaramaiah government. On his part, Siddaramaiah flexed his political muscle with a rally on October 5 at Manvi town in Raichur district where he asked supporters, "What wrong have I done? Can't the son of a shepherd become CM of the state twice?"

Despite the din over MUDA, senior Congress leaders brush aside any immediate threat to the CM, saying the latter would fight the allegations legally and that he had the party's backing. Still, the high command apparently had to intervene to quell speculation over a change of guard, triggered in part by the recent tete-a-tetes among senior ministers such as

THOSE WHO WAIT

The leaders being keenly watched with Siddaramaiah's mounting troubles



D.K. SHIVAKUMAR, *62*

He arm-wrestled with Siddaramaiah for the top job in 2023, having led the party to its most emphatic victory in over three decades. The terms of the truce were the deputy CM post and, apparently, a mid-term change of guard. Ever vigilant about the CM's popularity, he has been a steadfast deputy



G. PARAMESHWARA, *73*

Back in 2013, he missed a chance to become CM when the party, under his stewardship, won handsomely while he lost his seat. Polished and mild-mannered, the home minister is in the running to become the state's first Dalit CM



SATISH JARKIHOLI, *62*

Though he is content to wait until the next tenure for a shot at the top post, the Belagavi strongman—also the PWD minister—is very much a part of the buzz these days. His recent meetings with AICC chief Mallikarjun Kharge and fellow ministers have evoked much curiosity



H.C. MAHADEVAPPA, *71*

A wild card, Mahadevappa's name cropped up when he attended a meeting of top ministers recently. The Siddaramaiah loyalist is currently the minister for social welfare and an SC leader